

DESIGNER

PAUL POIRET

Known as *Le Magnifique* in Paris and the King of Fashion in the US, Poiret (1879–1944) was said by *The New Yorker* (1927) to have “helped to change the modern retina”. This brew of descriptions underlines three aspects of the man who dominated Parisian and international fashion in the 1910s – a theatrical orientalism, a new talent for branding and promotion, and a blending of clothes with avant-garde art. Poiret started auspiciously, working for two leading turn-of-the-century *maisons*: Jacques Doucet, then House of Worth. When he opened his own Parisian couture house around 1903, he set about overturning Belle Epoque fashion values. European women had been enslaved to a corseted waist, more or less, since the Renaissance. From 1903 Poiret set out to free them from the petticoat, and then the corset, in favour of looser, leaner lines. Although others, such as Madeleine Vionnet, also endorsed corset-free fashion, Poiret stole the limelight with vigorous self-promotion.

Draping by design

With a new silhouette came Poiret's fresh take on structuring garments. He replaced classic 19th-century pattern-dependent tailoring with an inspired draping of fabric and let garments hang from the shoulders. Between 1906 and World War I Poiret experimented with bold shapes inspired by a more natural female form and his own take on oriental luxury. Beginning with the svelte, empire-waisted lines of his startlingly simple Directoire garments, recalling French styles of the late 1700s and early 1800s, he pushed aside the subdued Edwardian palette, and added striking colours and exotic turbans. The year 1910 saw hobble skirts, so narrow at the ankles that walking was almost impossible. The next three years brought harem pants, followed by a minaret or lampshade tunic

shape in colourful beaded and fur-trimmed silks and chiffons. Confucius cloaks, kimonos, cocoon coats, and African kaftans were popular shapes.

Fusing fashion, theatre, and art

A sense of theatre was integral to Poiret's work, the oriental costumes of the Ballets Russes in productions such as *Schéhérazade* (1910) being a major influence. Poiret's lampshade tunic appeared in his costume designs for an orientalist play called *Le Minaret*. Placing his young wife, Denise, in the audience at the Paris première

of the play in 1913, dressed in a similar garment, was a mark of Poiret's genius for promotion. Poiret showed women how to make their fantasies into daily reality. Famed for lavish events – such as a Persian-themed fancy-dress party entitled “The Thousand and Second Night” (1911), co-hosted by a Poiret-dressed Denise – the business-savvy Poiret is often credited with inventing the glitzy fashion launch. Under Poiret's influence, fashion became part of a total artistic lifestyle. A keen painter himself, Poiret collaborated with artists such as Raoul Dufy and Erté, elevating clothes to an art form. He founded a decorative arts school in 1911, worked in interior design, and pioneered the couturier perfume business.

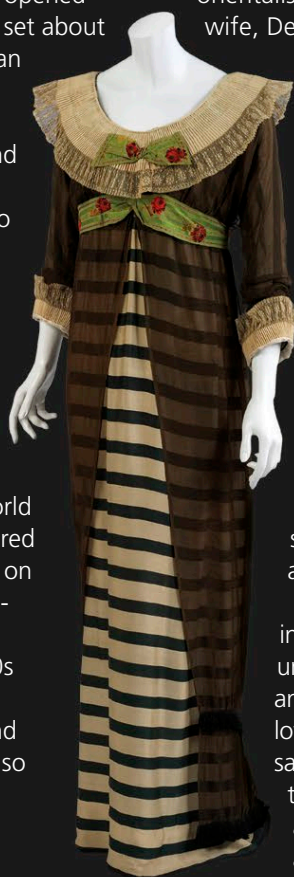
Nicknamed the Prophet of Simplicity by *Vogue* in 1913, there is irony in the fact that Poiret was undone by modernism. He was dismayed by the androgynous 1920s *garçonne* look and Chanel's love of black over colour. Although the 1920s saw his business in dire straits, he remains a towering fashion influence on designers such as Proenza Schouler, Prada, Hussein Chalayan, and Rei Kawakubo.

**△ NEW WAYS OF WORKING**

Poiret painstakingly fits a house model, draping fabric direct on to the body and cutting material in straight lines. Despite the lean simplicity, his look was sensual, elegant, and feminine.

◁ EMPIRE LINES

A Directoire-style evening dress from 1910, in forest green and ivory striped silk and black silk chiffon. This neoclassical columnar shape was revolutionary in the age of the corseted S-curve. Collar and cuffs are made from a traditional French cartridge-pleated linen bonnet, while the high waistline is caught with the folkloric brocaded ribbon that Poiret adored.



TIMELINE

1879 Born in Paris

1898 Starts work for Paris couturier Jacques Doucet, and creates an early stir

1901 Joins the House of Worth, Paris, under Gaston Worth

○ 1900

c.1903 Founds his first fashion *maison* in rue Auber, Paris

1906 Launches the simple, empire-line Directoire Revival look and begins the liberation from corsetry

○ 1910

1910 Designs hobble skirts – an impractical, oriental-led fashion

▷ 1911 La Perse coat, in silk and fur, features fabric designed by Raoul Dufy. Harem pants appear



▷ 1913 Iconic Poiret lampshade-minaret shapes launched



○ 1920

1922 Beaded, oriental-flavour evening dresses in hot Poiret colours

○ 1930

1929 Closes his fashion business

1944 Dies penniless in Paris

◁ **MADAME POIRET, 1919** Denise Poiret was her husband's muse and most effective advertisement – her naturally slim figure promoted his designs perfectly.